the waters on reconciliation as envisioned by London. 'Being a very clever politician and someone capable of thinking very well on his feet and doing things about it, the moment they [London] said reconciliation, he [Karzai] said yes, Loya Jirga. And he took, to some extent, the initiative away from them', says Mukhopadhaya who actively engaged with Karzai and his team on this issue.[110] India continued to create parallel political constituencies in Afghanistan and the region to ensure that the London reconciliation plan failed. Though popular demand for reconciliation had strengthened the conciliators over the partisans, India continued to fight diplomatic battles in Washington and in the Istanbul process to counter the British line. 'We found the French [Chantilly process] to be much more sensible about this than the British, but a lot of Indian diplomats say that Britain has no longer any strategic thinking left outside the EU. They have just given it all up', says Pramit Pal Chaudhuri.[111]

Much like it had done in the pre-1996 phase by using the UN to advocate its stance on Afghanistan, India had adopted an internationalist multi-stakeholder strategy in 2010 to strike a strategic balance between Afghanistan and Pakistan. Though political ground for partisans remained strong in 2010 just like in the 1990s, India's regional partners were not in the mood for muscular intervention in Afghanistan. Neither Iran nor Russia had the appetite to get militarily entangled in Afghanistan. A cooperative regional approach, thus, was the only way forward. Partisan advocacy of marginalising Pakistan or building extra-governmental politico-military alliances in Afghanistan did not fit this paradigm. Resultantly, similar to the 1992 Rao Doctrine, building international consensus for an Afghan-led and Afghan-owned peace process was India's conciliatory response to the evolving geopolitical dynamics. Surely, Pakistan was to be part of this process, but not as a dominating power. As Bhadrakumar, an old-time conciliator said, 'it was an aberration that a civilisation like India with such insight into the shades of political Islam had a mental bloc about the Taliban. No country today questions the wisdom of reconciling with the Taliban.'[112] Not only did New Delhi accept reconciliation, but, by not blocking Pakistan out of regional conferences (like Islamabad was doing with India), New Delhi hoped to assuage Pakistan's concerns about India's attempts to strategically encircle its neighbours.